

History lessons: On the French Open

The top layer in men's and women's tennis now **sports** a settled look

The **yearning** for historical greatness **is** common among sports fans. **Contemporary** success and genius **notwithstanding**, there is **often** a tendency to **hark back to** the past and **lament** that present-day **virtuosi** are not a patch on the older ones. In tennis, this storyline was expected to **unfold in the immediate aftermath of** the 'Big Three' **era** as Roger Federer and Rafael Nadal exited, and Novak Djokovic started displaying his **waning** powers. **It is to** Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner's **credit** that they have allowed none of this talk to surface. Sunday's **fascinating five-set** French Open final was the latest piece of evidence as the **Spaniard outlasted** the World No. 1 over five hours and 29 minutes of intense, **scintillating** action. The victory brought Alcaraz his fifth **Grand Slam** trophy, and the World No. 2 became only the third man after Gustavo Kuerten and Nadal to defend titles at Roland-Garros this millennium. Alcaraz and Sinner have now **swept** the last six **Majors** and eight of the previous 11. They are firmly **perched** at the top of tennis' current **totem pole**, and **going by** the 12th act of their **engrossing** play in Paris, there is little doubt that it is their **rivalry** that will prove **era-defining** for the men's game.

Leading in, it was Sinner who had been more **clinical**, with the **highlight** being the **ruthless dismantling** of 24-time Major winner Djokovic in the semifinal. The 23-year-old had won 29 **straight sets** at Slams this year, and when he made it 31 by **pocketing** the first two against Alcaraz, a third straight Major — fourth overall — **loomed**. But **Alcaraz**, who came in after triumphs in Monte Carlo and Rome, **found a higher gear** when threatened — erasing three match points in the fourth set, breaking Sinner when the Italian was serving for the championship and **overcoming** his own disappointment of failing to serve it out in the fifth **stanza** to turn the tables fully. Saturday's women's final between No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka and No. 2 Coco Gauff was as dramatic and **capricious**, but **alternated** between middling and **glorious**. **In the end**, it was Gauff who proved **steadier**, overcoming some **treacherous** conditions and her **erratic** opponent in two hours and 38 minutes. **Sabalenka**, in fact, **was** the favourite, having also **ousted** three-time defending champion Iga Swiatek **en route**. But her power-packed game **crumbled in the face of** Gauff's **restrained** art as the American left her **nursing consecutive** defeats in Slam finals. For Gauff, 21, it was her second Major, and with a technique that is gradually improving, she is sure to rise further.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject-verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

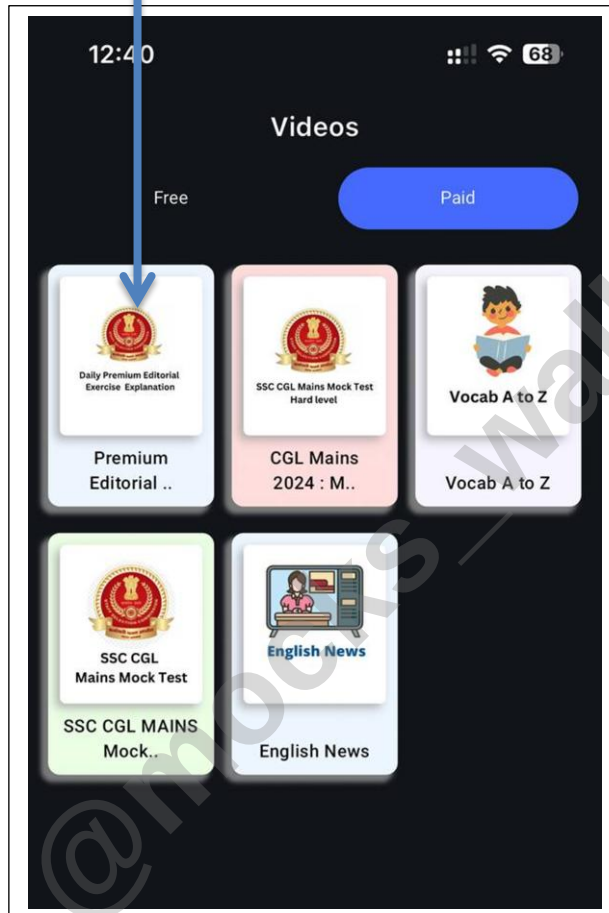
Vocabulary

1. **Sport** (verb) – display, exhibit, show off, flaunt, parade प्रदर्शन करना
2. **Yearning** (noun) – longing, desire, craving, urge, hankering तीव्र इच्छा
3. **Contemporary** (adjective) – modern, current, present-day, up-to-date, recent समकालीन
4. **Notwithstanding** (preposition) – despite, in spite of, although, regardless of, even though इसके बावजूद
5. **Often** (adverb) – frequently, regularly, commonly, repeatedly, usually अक्सर
6. **Hark back to** (phrase) – recall, remember, reminisce, refer back, evoke अतीत की याद करना
7. **Lament** (verb) – mourn, grieve, regret, bemoan, bewail शोक मनाना
8. **Virtuosi** (plural noun) – experts, maestros, geniuses, prodigies, specialists कला के उस्ताद
9. **Unfold** (verb) – develop, evolve, emerge, occur, transpire प्रकट होना
10. **In the aftermath of** (phrase) – following, after, as a result of, subsequent to, ensuing के बाद
11. **Era** (noun) – age, period, epoch, time, generation युग
12. **Waning** (adjective) – declining, diminishing, weakening, fading, decreasing घटता हुआ
13. **It is to someone's credit** (phrase) – praise-worthy, admirable, commendable, deserving recognition, notable किसी की प्रशंसा योग्य बात
14. **Fascinating** (adjective) – captivating, interesting, engaging, enchanting, intriguing आकर्षक
15. **Five-set** (noun) – a match format where players compete in a "best of five" sets पाँच सेट वाला मैच
16. **Spaniard** (adjective) – Spanish, Iberian, Castilian, Latin, Hispanic स्पेनवासी
17. **Outlast** (verb) – survive, endure, persist, withstand, remain अधिक समय तक टिके रहना
18. **Scintillating** (adjective) – brilliant, dazzling, sparkling, thrilling, exciting रोमांचक
19. **Grand Slam** (noun) – the winning of all the individual championships that comprise a Grand Slam. प्रमुख टेनिस टूर्नामेंट
20. **Sweep** (verb) – dominate, win all, take over, claim, capture पूरी तरह जीतना
21. **Major** (noun) – an important sports competition, especially in tennis or golf

22. **Perch** (verb) – sit, position, rest, settle, roost ऊपर स्थिति होना
23. **Totem pole** (noun) – hierarchy, ranking, order, status level, tier पदानुक्रम
24. **Go by** (phrasal verb) – judge by, refer to, rely on, follow, take into account के अनुसार
25. **Engross** (verb) – absorb, captivate, immerse, grip, engage पूरी तरह आकर्षित करना
26. **Rivalry** (noun) – competition, conflict, duel, contention, opposition प्रतिद्वंद्विता
27. **Era-defining** (adjective) – historic, epoch-making, landmark, pivotal, monumental युग-परिवर्तक
28. **Clinical** (adjective) – precise, efficient, professional, exact, unemotional सटीक / निष्पक्ष
29. **Highlight** (noun) – best part, main point, key moment, climax, focal point मुख्य आकर्षण
30. **Ruthless** (adjective) – merciless, harsh, brutal, unrelenting, pitiless निर्दयी
31. **Dismantling** (noun) – destruction, disassembly, deconstruction, demolition, breakdown विघटन
32. **Straight set** (noun) – a match where one player wins without losing a single set
33. **Pocket** (verb) – grab, claim, win, secure, take जीतना
34. **Loom** (verb) – appear, emerge, threaten, hover, approach मंडराना
35. **Find a higher gear** (phrase) – increase intensity, perform better, push harder, accelerate, elevate effort बेहतर प्रदर्शन करना
36. **Overcome** (verb) – conquer, defeat, prevail, triumph, master पार पाना
37. **Stanza** (noun) – segment, round, part, set, section भाग / चरण
38. **Capricious** (adjective) – unpredictable, erratic, whimsical, unstable, changeable चंचल
39. **Alternate** (verb) – switch, rotate, oscillate, interchange, vary बारी-बारी से होना
40. **Glorious** (adjective) – splendid, magnificent, grand, superb, resplendent शानदार
41. **In the end** (phrase) – finally, ultimately, eventually, at last, after all अंततः
42. **Steady** (adjective) – stable, consistent, firm, solid, reliable स्थिर
43. **Treacherous** (adjective) – dangerous, risky, perilous, unsafe, tricky खतरनाक

44. **Erratic** (adjective) – unpredictable, inconsistent, unstable, variable, irregular अनियमित
45. **Oust** (verb) – remove, expel, overthrow, displace, eject बाहर करना
46. **En route** (adverb) – during the course of a journey; on the way. को जाते हुए
47. **Crumble** (verb) – collapse, fall apart, break down, shatter, disintegrate ढह जाना
48. **In the face of** (phrase) – despite, in spite of, against, even with, confronting के बावजूद
49. **Restrained** (adjective) – controlled, measured, subdued, moderate, calm संयमित
50. **Nursing** (verb) – harbouring, suffering from, nurturing, carrying, dealing with झेलना
51. **Consecutive** (adjective) – successive, sequential, uninterrupted, following, continuous लगातार

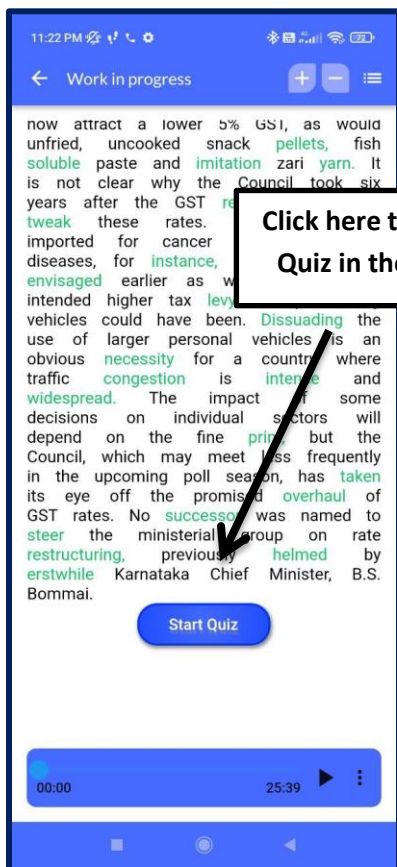
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



Summary of the Editorial

1. Sports fans often long for the **glory of past eras**, especially in tennis after the decline of the Big Three (Federer, Nadal, Djokovic).
2. **Carlos Alcaraz** and **Jannik Sinner** have effectively quelled such nostalgia with their **rising dominance**.
3. The recent **French Open final** showcased their era-defining rivalry, with Alcaraz defeating Sinner in **five intense sets** over 5 hours and 29 minutes.
4. This victory marked **Alcaraz's fifth Grand Slam** title and a strong case for his growing legacy.
5. He became only the **third man** this century (after Kuerten and Nadal) to **defend the French Open title**.
6. Between them, Alcaraz and Sinner have **won six straight Majors** and 8 of the last 11, cementing their dominance.
7. Sinner entered the final in **superb form**, having defeated Djokovic convincingly in the semifinal.
8. He had **won 31 straight sets** in Grand Slams this year, starting strong by winning the first two sets of the final.
9. Alcaraz staged a thrilling comeback, saving **three match points** and turning the match around dramatically.
10. He showed **mental resilience**, especially after failing to serve out the match in the fifth set but regaining control.
11. The women's final between **Aryna Sabalenka** and **Coco Gauff** was similarly gripping, though more **inconsistent**.
12. Despite being the favourite and having defeated Iga Swiatek, **Sabalenka faltered**, struggling with inconsistency.
13. **Gauff**, with increasing maturity, played a composed game to win her **second Grand Slam** title.
14. At just **21 years old**, Gauff's game is evolving, and she's poised for **further success**.
15. Both finals underscore that the **top layer of men's and women's tennis is now clearly settled**, with rising stars ready to shape the sport's new golden era.

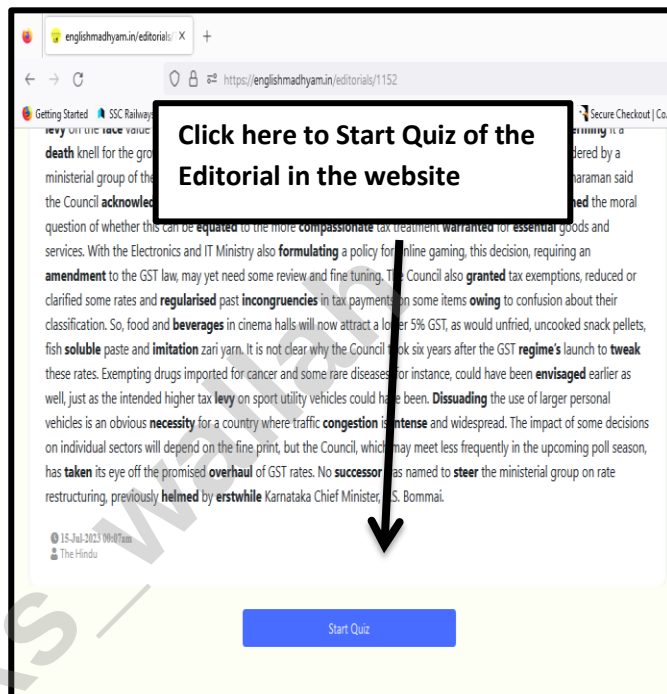
Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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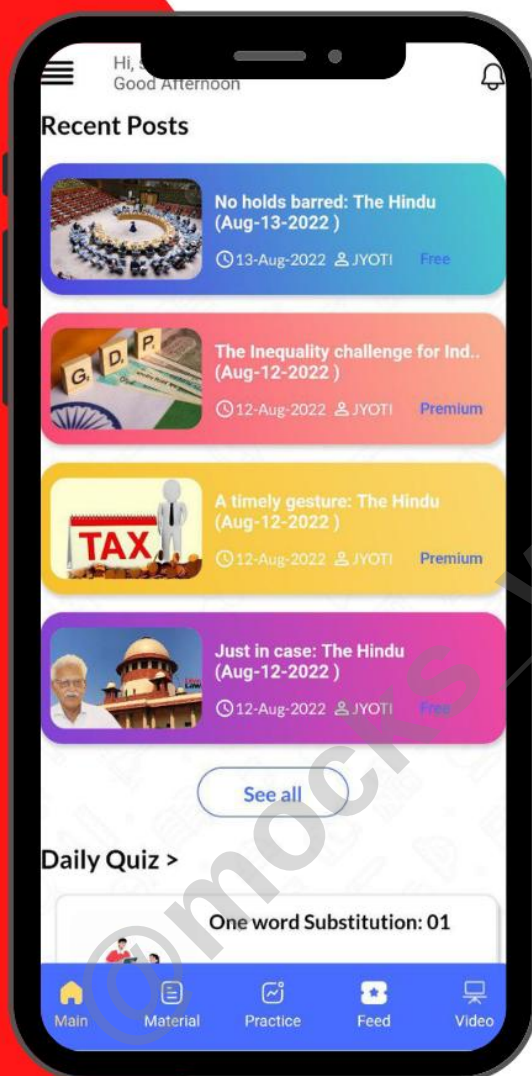
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